Move Pen Move

By Shane Koyczan

INTRODUCTION

When your mother dies, lessons learned when you were four become much more meaningful. Sometimes the air thins and you gasp for breath just sitting in a chair. You lose something vast and precious that you didn't even know you had. Your chance to repay an enormous debt is lost. The one person who would take on anyone, or anything (any army for that matter) in your defense is no longer there for you. You very much want to give a big hug to every little old lady you meet. . . and you would love for them to hug you back.

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Stay

That's what mothers say when their sons and daughters go away

They say stay

My mother said go

So I wasn't there the night she fell out of her wheelchair

So frustrated that she amputated her legs . . . rather tried to with a steak knife

Her life lay on the white floor like

Roses in the snow

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Our relationship was an anthem composed of words like

"gotta go"

So we went

And sent our regards on post cards from the places we've been

Stories about all the things we've seen

That's how it was with you and I

Why say good bye when we could still write

And then I took your hands

We should have practiced our good-byes

Because then I took your eyes

And I was somewhere in the middle of nowhere

Watching the sun rise

Over a stop sign placed down the center line of a high way full of sudden turns for the worse

Running back home cause I gotta play nurse

Gotta figure out which pill alleviates which pain

Which part of your brain is being used for a boxing bag

As your body became a never ending game of freeze tag

Taking place in an empty playground

That was left looking for your limbs in the lost and found and I couldn't set you free

So we just sat there

Our heads bent towards each other like flowers in the small hours of the morning

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While light wondering in like a warning that
Time is passing
And you right along with it
Bit by bit everyday
And all I can say is if I could I would write you some way
out of this
But my gift is useless
And you said no
Write me a poem to make me happy
So I wrote move pen move
Write me a bedroom where curse make love to our cancers
But my mother just motions to a bottle full of answers and says
Help me go
And I know something of how pianos feel when it looks at the fireplace to see sheet music
Being used for kindling
Smoke signaling the end of some song that it thought would take too long to learn
Now I just sit here and watch you burn away
All those notes never had a chance to play to hear the music of what you had to say
But I count out the pills just to see if I can do it
I can't even get half way through it before I turn back into your son and say

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Stay
I could hook up my heart to your ears and let my tears be your morphine drip
Because maybe it's easier to let you slip away than it is to say goodbye
So I hold my breath
Because in the countdown to death the question of why melts into when
How much time do we have left
Because if I knew what I know now then
I would say move pen move
Write me a mountain
Because head stones are not big enough
And my mother says
Stop it
Write me a poem to make me happy
So I write this
Stay
She smiles and says
Gotta go
I know
Good bye. . .

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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